one occasion, he remarked that 'there is so much that I want to do, *lekin yeh babu karne nahin dete*' (but these bureaucrats don't allow me to).

Emergency Powers

During the Doklam Crisis of 2017, Emergency Powers had been delegated to the Service HQ, wherein capital and revenue purchases of up to Rs 300 crore could be made without reference to the ministry or the IFA. Gen Rawat, who had been the COAS during the Doklam crisis, had seen the advantage accrued. Now, as the CDS he wasted no time in getting Emergency Powers delegated once again, when the crisis in Eastern Ladakh erupted in June 2020. However, these Emergency Powers (EP-1) were given grudgingly starting from August 2020 for six months only, i.e., up to December 2020, effectively giving a window of only five months and with caveats. First, all contracts had to be concluded during the duration of the delegated powers, and second, the delivery of the contracted items was to be completed within one year of signing the contract. This was the bureaucracy hitting back. These twin conditions virtually ruled out the acquisition of many critical items, as the procurement process had still to be followed in toto, while the world was reeling under the disruptions caused by the Covid pandemic. EP-2 and EP-3 were also given in the same six-monthly tranches, up to December 2020, and with the same restrictions. If only the initial EP had been given unreservedly for a duration of one year, the operational benefit would have been immense.

Nevertheless, all the Directorates and Branches in the Army HQ took it upon themselves to make the most of these delegated powers and worked through the Covid restrictions.

Copyright @ Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation